

MODDABLE CHESS · VARIANT 84 OF 153

# Los Alamos

**6×6**

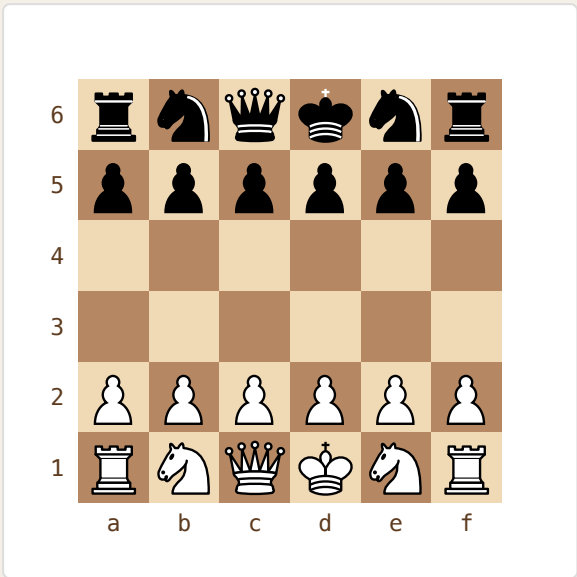
BOARD

**2**

PLAYERS

# LOS ALAMOS

The first chess variant ever played by a computer (1956, MANIAC I at Los Alamos National Laboratory). A 6×6 board with no Bishops and no castling.



*Los Alamos Chess – starting position (6×6)*

## SETUP

**Board:** 6×6 (six files, six ranks).

**Setup (FEN):** rnqknr/pppppp/6/6/PPPPPP/RNQKNR

Each side: Rook, Knight, Queen, King, Knight, Rook (+ 6 pawns). No Bishops.

## RULES

- ♦ Standard chess movement for all pieces (Rooks, Knights, Queen, King, Pawns).
- ♦ No Bishops exist in this variant.
- ♦ No castling.
- ♦ Pawns move one square forward only (no double-step from starting rank).
- ♦ No en passant (since there's no double-step).
- ♦ Pawns promote on the far rank to Queen, Rook, or Knight (no Bishop promotion since Bishops don't exist).

## WIN CONDITION

Checkmate or stalemate the opponent (stalemate is a loss in Los Alamos rules).

## STRATEGY

Without Bishops, there are no long-range diagonal attackers. Knights become relatively more powerful since the board is smaller (fewer moves to cross). The Queen is overwhelmingly strong on a 6×6 board — trade it only for the opposing Queen. Games are short and tactical. The smaller board means Kings have fewer escape squares, making endgame mating patterns easier.

## ATTRIBUTION

Paul Stein and Mark Wells, Los Alamos National Laboratory, 1956. Public domain.